

Picture Wall — Restoration Project (2015–2026)

دیوار جہانگیری — بحالی منصوبہ

1. Basic Facts

- Led by: Aga Khan Cultural Service-Pakistan (AKCS-P), under the guidance of the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC)
- Partner: Government of Punjab's Walled City of Lahore Authority (WCLA)
- Duration: 2015-2026 (documentation from September 2015; full completion acknowledged by UNESCO in May 2026)
- Cost: Not documented in available sources

2. Construction Details

- Phase 1 (from September 2015): comprehensive documentation using 3D laser scanning, Electronic Distance Measurement (EDM) instruments, and high-resolution ortho-rectified photography — described as the first project of this technical scale ever undertaken in Pakistan.
- Prototype phase (2015-2018): an 11 m x 16 m section of the western facade was selected for trial conservation, reviewed by an international workshop of conservators and chemists in January 2018 to establish techniques and principles before scaling up.
- Techniques applied: removal of later, inappropriate plaster; biofilm treatment; reintegration of fresco and brick-imitation work; consolidation of tile mosaics and glazes using a silica-based binder injected into micro-holes to restore adhesion and reduce porosity; artificially manufactured imitation tiles used to reintegrate missing mosaic sections in a way that is legible as restoration rather than passed off as original fabric; new lime plaster colour- and texture-matched to the original applied to exposed brick and gaps.

3. Historical Background

- Milestone (4 May 2019): Prime Minister Imran Khan inaugurated the completed restoration of the 240-foot western facade segment; he specifically encouraged Pakistani educational institutions to develop archaeology as a field of study and cited AKDN's sustainable heritage-tourism models as inspiration.
- Completion (May 2026): UNESCO formally acknowledged completion of the full restoration project, covering roughly 2,000 decorated panels across the wall's full extent. AKCS-P CEO Tausif Khawaja and UNESCO's Pakistan country representative Fuad Pashayev both framed the project as proof that world-class heritage conservation is achievable in Pakistan.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- A notably high proportion of the young Pakistani professionals trained on this project - conservation scientists, surface conservators, conservation architects, archaeologists and ceramists - were women, according to project reporting.

- The project's 3D laser scanning and EDM documentation work was described as the first of its technical scale ever undertaken in Pakistan - meaning the Picture Wall restoration was also a milestone for Pakistani heritage-conservation technology generally, not just for this one wall.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Picture a young Pakistani conservation scientist in 2016, injecting an almost invisible silica binder into a single loose tile through a micro-hole smaller than a grain of rice - one tile, out of roughly two thousand, in a project that would take over a decade to finish and would end, in 2026, with UNESCO itself confirming the wall was whole again.

AI Heritage Revive — Lahore Fort landmark reference. Compiled from encyclopedic research report; figures marked "Not documented" are intentionally left blank rather than estimated.